



PANEL IN SESSION, DWARKADAS J. SANGHVI COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING, MUMBAI

CAMPUS SERIES | INSIGHTS REPORT | SEPTEMBER 2026

Beyond the Fear

How AI is reshaping work, skills and assessment, and what students, educators and employers must do next

HOST

Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai

DATE

21 September 2026

ORGANISED BY

Aegis Knowledge Trust

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This insights report distils the first panel in the Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series, held at Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai. It brings together views from Google, HDFC Life, fintech, technology consulting and academia, moderated by the CEO of Aegis School of Data Science & AI, before an audience of engineering students.

Quotes have been lightly edited for clarity. Figures and examples are as cited by panellists during the discussion and have not been independently verified. The full recording is available on the AegisTV YouTube channel.

AT A GLANCE

AI, work and skills: what the panel saw from the front line

AI is compressing the time it takes to produce work, but not the time it takes to understand it. The panel's examples show why fundamentals, judgement and ownership now decide who gets hired.

15 min

To produce software with AI that once took days to write by hand

Cited by Dr. Ashish Tendulkar, Google

0 of 100

Experienced candidates who found the bug in a two-page C program within 15 minutes

Cited by Bhupesh Daheria

2_x

Times an AI agent deleted a production database at the moderator's own company

Cited by Bhupesh Daheria

~10

Research papers DJSCE students read before starting a project

Cited by Dr. Kriti Srivastava, DJSCE

100 cities

Real coordinates in an A* routing problem that replaced textbook coding exercises

Cited by Dr. Kriti Srivastava, DJSCE

4 to 6

Levels of Bloom's taxonomy that separate effective AI users from the rest

Cited by Bhupesh Daheria

Three messages from the panel

Tasks change, roles remain

Coding, testing and first drafts are being absorbed by AI. Judgement, accountability and decisions stay with people.

Fundamentals are the moat

Everyone has the same AI tools. Deep subject knowledge is what lets you instruct AI well and verify what it produces.

Assessment must evolve

When machines write the answers, evaluation must test reasoning, defence and application, not recall.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Automating tasks, not responsibilities

Public debate about AI swings between two extremes: AI will take every job, or AI will end humanity. This panel set both aside and asked a practical question. If AI neither destroys nor replaces us, how exactly is it changing jobs, skills, hiring and education?

Panellists from Google, HDFC Life, fintech, technology consulting and academia reached a clear, shared conclusion. AI is automating tasks, not responsibilities. The job title stays; what sits beneath it changes.

In that world, the winners are not those who can use AI tools, since everyone can. They are those who can instruct AI well, judge its output critically and take ownership of the result.



“The task will be replaced, the responsibility remains the same. Rebuild your problem-solving skills and identify which problem is worth solving.”

Bhupesh Daheria, Moderator

KEY FINDINGS

1

Tasks change, roles remain

AI absorbs coding, testing, data cleaning and first drafts. Accountability and decisions stay human.

2

Fundamentals are the differentiator

Using AI is not a skill. Using it effectively, on strong fundamentals, is.

3

Problem solving decides hiring

Recruiters are moving to live problem solving and code modification, because AI-assisted submissions look alike.

4

Human skills gain value

Leadership, empathy, reading a room and teamwork remain beyond AI's reach.

5

Agents need managing

Agentic AI will automate whole workflows, but agents lack judgement and must be supervised like teammates.

6

Assessment must evolve

Presentation, defence, continuous evaluation and applied problems are replacing recall-based exams.

7

Opportunity lies beyond software

AI will power civil, mechanical, legal, health and governance innovation, and create new fields.

THE PANEL

Six perspectives from industry and academia

The panel brought together people who build AI, people who hire for it and people who teach it, in front of an audience made up largely of computer engineering students.



Bhupesh Daheria

MODERATOR

CEO, Aegis School of Data Science & AI; Founder, Assessfy



Dr. Ashish Tendulkar

BIG TECH

AI Practice Manager, Google



Bala Singhanian

INDUSTRY

Chief Data and Analytics Officer, Group Head and EVP, HDFC Life



Dr. Kriti Srivastava

ACADEMIA

Head of the Department, Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering



Virendra Pal

FINTECH

AI and FinTech Expert



Sudarshan Shidore

DATA SCIENCE AND START-UPS

Startup Founder and Former Chief Data Scientist, Tata Consultancy Services

HOST

Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi
College of Engineering,
Vile Parle (West), Mumbai

DATE

Monday, 21 September
2026

FORMAT

Moderated panel followed
by open audience Q&A

AUDIENCE

Engineering students,
mostly computer science
and applications, and
faculty



WATCH THE FULL DISCUSSION

AI and Employability: Opportunities, Challenges and the Future of Work

Panel discussion at Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai, including audience Q&A

youtube.com/watch?v=fIPXB3mTNOM

IN THE ROOM

Where the Campus Series began



Opening the session with the traditional lamp lighting at Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai.

DJSCE hosted the first panel in the Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series. Students were invited to ask anything, setting aside only politics and religion, and their questions on hiring, coding and social impact shaped the second half of the session.

6

voices across Big Tech, BFSI, fintech and academia

1st

panel in the Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series



Panelists with DJSCE faculty and the organising team.



Felicitation of panelists by the host.



The panel in discussion, with the Bharat AI Innovation pre-event screen behind.



Voices from the stage. Panellists responding to the moderator and to questions from the floor.



"Whenever fear-mongering happens, discount it. Take it with a pinch of salt."

Bhupesh Daheria, Moderator, opening the session

FROM THE FLOOR What students asked the panel

Q1

How can AI be used for social good and to solve public problems?

See chapter 06

Q2

If everyone uses AI, how will recruiters evaluate candidates?

See chapter 07

Q3

Why learn C and write code by hand when Python and AI exist?

See chapter 07

Q4

How much does domain knowledge matter in fresher hiring?

See chapter 06

WORK AT THE TASK LEVEL

01 The task changes, the responsibility remains

The moderator set aside the two dominant narratives, that AI will replace every worker or end humanity, and asked what is actually changing inside jobs.

Discount the fear

Bhupesh Daheria argued that much of today's alarm is shaped by political and business agendas, including pressure to justify heavy AI investment. Society has long managed serious risks, from a gas cylinder at home to nuclear weapons.

What changes inside the job

Dr. Ashish Tendulkar described the shift from inside Google: the "how" of work is increasingly handled by AI. Software that once took days can now be produced in about 15 minutes. But quality depends on instruction and review: poor prompts produce junior-level code, while top-tier code needs expert prompting and review.

EXHIBIT 1 What AI absorbs, and what stays human

AI increasingly does	People still own
Writing and testing code	Understanding context
Data cleaning and preparation	Judging whether output is production-grade
First drafts and options	Choosing what a real customer will use
Debugging routine errors	Accountability for the result

Source: Bharat AI Innovation analysis of remarks by Dr. Ashish Tendulkar and Bhupesh Daheria.

What professionals now need

- **Deep domain understanding:** data structures, algorithms and system design still matter.
- **Strong communication and judgement:** articulating what you want, and deciding which of AI's many options works.



"You require great communication skills and deep understanding of the domain to instruct AI and to judge what AI has done."

Dr. Ashish Tendulkar, AI Practice Manager, Google

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Job titles such as Software Engineer remain, but the tasks underneath them are being automated.
- Working with AI demands higher cognitive capability, not less.

02 HOW PEOPLE LEARN

The three domains of learning

Sudarshan Shidore framed the change through the three classical domains of learning, and argued that AI affects each of them very differently.

EXHIBIT 2 Impact of AI across the three domains of learning

Domain	What it covers	AI impact	Panel view
Cognitive	Thinking, reasoning, information processing	HIGH	How we absorb information, and how we feed it to AI, is changing fundamentally.
Affective	Emotional intelligence, attitudes, leadership, dealing with people	LOW	AI cannot lead a meeting, read body language or sense who is engaged.
Psychomotor	Physical skill and movement, such as sport or choreography	MINIMAL	Largely untouched by AI today.

Source: framework presented by Sudarshan Shidore. Impact ratings summarise the panel's view and are qualitative.

Context is everything

Even within the cognitive domain, AI cannot be used well without context. Without context you cannot ask the right questions, and wrong answers compound. Asking the right question, he argued, is the central skill of the AI era.

Invest in what AI cannot do

Affective skills, context, soft skills and original thinking deserve deliberate investment. The moderator added that AI can imitate empathy but does not possess it, which is a large part of why people remain irreplaceable.



“AI is not going to tell you who is getting bored and who is getting excited by the idea. AI is not going to do group work for you.”

Sudarshan Shidore, Former Chief Data Scientist, TCS

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Use AI to sharpen cognitive skills, not to replace them.
- Leadership, empathy and teamwork are becoming more valuable, not less.
- Context and good questions are the bridge between human expertise and AI output.

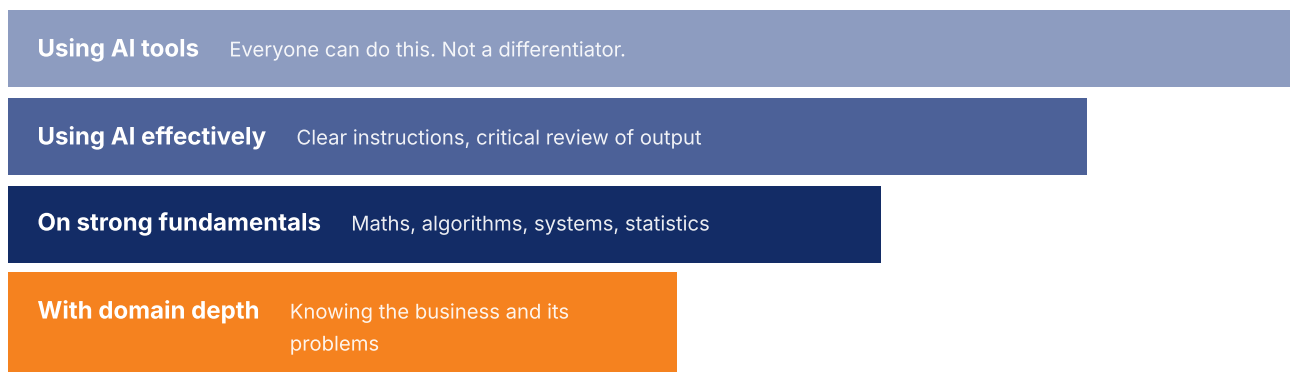
03 THE HIRING VIEW

Problem solving is the real differentiator

Bala Singhania brought good news from the hiring side: HDFC Life is hiring more data scientists, data engineers and AI engineers than any other role. The challenge is how candidates stand out.

PROBLEM	SOLUTION	ADVANTAGE
- Every candidate has the same AI tools, so "better prompting" cannot answer "why should I hire you?" - Over-reliance on AI risks weakening independent problem solving. - Recruiters find it harder to tell candidates apart.	- Attempt the problem yourself first, on paper or a whiteboard, then use AI to refine it. - Understand the business you want to join, its customers and challenges. - Build depth in a chosen domain.	- A thin app wrapped around someone else's model has no moat. - Fundamental domain understanding is what makes a professional hard to replace.

EXHIBIT 3 The capability stack: from using AI to being hard to replace



Source: Bharat AI Innovation synthesis of remarks by Bala Singhania, HDFC Life. Narrower bars indicate rarer, more valuable capability.



"Using Claude is not a skill. Using Claude effectively may be a skill, but it has to be based on a more fundamental level of knowledge in the area of your choice."

Bala Singhania, Chief Data and Analytics Officer, HDFC Life

He drew a parallel with arithmetic: using a calculator is not a problem, but not knowing how to add is.

04 AGENTIC AI

The agentic shift

Virendra Pal described how AI agents are moving from helping with tasks to running whole workflows, and what that means for data and machine learning roles.

EXHIBIT 4 What agents will automate, and what stays human

AGENTS WILL AUTOMATE

- Connecting databases and preparing data
- Handling missing values and building initial models
- Routine deployment, increasingly as purchasable agents and reusable skills

PEOPLE WILL DECIDE

- Thresholds, and how a model is used in the business
- Where to apply it, such as which customer segment to target
- High-stakes calls in underwriting, collections and pricing

Source: Virendra Pal, AI and FinTech Expert.

Hiring shifts already visible

- He has stopped hiring general Python coders, a role he hired routinely a few years ago.
- Data scientists are hired for research on unsolved problems; ML engineers for integration and engineering.
- Engineers who read research papers and implement them build a clear technical edge.
- An app built in 15 minutes can be hacked as quickly if its builder does not understand security, databases and token costs.

Agents need managing

The moderator added a caution from his own companies: agents are logical but have no judgement, and one deleted a production database twice. In a client setting, such an error can trigger penalties and serious damage. Students will compete not only with people but with vast numbers of agents, and must learn to manage agents as carefully as teammates.

He also flagged falling attention spans and reading capability. Higher-order thinking, levels four to six of Bloom's taxonomy, is what separates effective AI users from the rest.



"The future is definitely agentic. But the value still depends on you: the threshold you decide, and how it is implemented in the business."

Virendra Pal, AI and FinTech Expert

05 ASSESSMENT

Rethinking assessment

The moderator put a pointed question to academia: if machines write the assignment and humans grade it, and exam answers are freely available online, is the current system building the capability students need?

Dr. Kriti Srivastava described how DJSCE, using its autonomy and the direction set by the National Education Policy, has been reshaping evaluation.

EXHIBIT 5 How assessment is changing at DJSCE

Practice	What it looks like
Paper-and-pen exams retained	Students must understand algorithms deeply, for example what parameter tuning actually means, not just call a library.
Use AI, then present and defend	AI tools are allowed in projects, but marks depend on the student's ability to present and explain the work.
Continuous evaluation	A single 100-mark end-semester paper replaced by weekly lab evaluation, quizzes and multiple components.
Application-oriented problems	For example, using the A* algorithm on real coordinates of 100 cities to find the best route from Mumbai to Delhi and report the cost.
Research first	Projects begin with reading around ten research papers to see how others approached the problem.

Source: Dr. Kriti Srivastava, Head of the Department, DJSCE.



"You cannot be dependent on LLMs for planning a solution. Your plans should be your own plans, your own strategies."

Dr. Kriti Srivastava, Head of the Department, DJSCE

AI as a tutor, not an answer key

Dr. Ashish Tendulkar suggested reversing the usual pattern: work out your own solution first, then ask AI to critique it. Used this way, AI becomes a mentor, a brainstorming partner and a rehearsal space before presenting to a teacher. He also named what is lost when concepts are outsourced: the joy of understanding an elegant proof or algorithm, an experience that carries into other fields.

EXHIBIT 6 How industry evaluates AI-assisted work

DR. ASHISH TENDULKAR

Ownership

Use any tool you like, but you are responsible for the code you submit. AI cannot be held accountable; the person in the loop is.

INDUSTRY PRACTICE

Engineering discipline

Work broken into small change lists, with test cases and clear planning, which is hard to fake.

VIRENDRA PAL

Edge-case evaluation sets

Experience-based tests for latency, edge cases and production scenarios. Copied code fails many of them.

PANEL

Concept probing

If a random walk appears in the code, explain it. A float silently cast to an integer can shift business decisions in production.

BALA SINGHANIA

Live modification

Change your own code in front of the interviewer, in minutes, without AI.

SUDARSHAN SHIDORE

Defence

A presentation you did not think through cannot be defended. An AI-generated deck on LLM security collapsed under basic questions.

Source: panel discussion. Attributions indicate the panellist who raised each practice.

Bala Singhania noted that in his own student days, open-book, open-time exams were the hardest of all. Access to resources does not make evaluation easy; it shifts what is being tested.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Machine-written work graded by people is not a sustainable model; assess reasoning and defence instead.
- Continuous, applied evaluation tests understanding far better than a single end-of-term paper.
- Academia and industry are converging on the same principle: use AI freely, but own and explain every result.

100

marks in one end-semester paper, now split into weekly and multi-part evaluation

~10

research papers read before a project begins

6

ways industry now tests AI-assisted work

BEYOND SOFTWARE

06 AI beyond software, and why domain knowledge matters

AI has democratised programming. An economist at a large technology company, with no formal coding background, now builds economic models using AI coding tools. The same is open to lawyers, psychologists and engineers of every branch.

A second chance for core engineering

The moderator argued that three decades of the software boom drew talent and funding away from mechanical, civil, electrical and chemical engineering and the fundamental sciences. As software becomes more automated, talent can flow back to these fields, with AI as a force multiplier for better materials, low-cost housing, better roads and better governance.

EXHIBIT 7 AI for social good and governance: examples discussed

Area	Example
Child and women safety	Khozo, a crowdsourced facial recognition platform built by Aegis and offered free to the Goa government. A photo of a child found begging or at risk alerts the nearest police station, NGOs and the family.
Road infrastructure	Linking road contract data and specifications with pothole detection to trace poor quality back to the contractor.
Development planning	Correlating road density, night-light and population data to find under-served regions.
Affordable diagnostics	An Indian health-tech start-up pairing a smartphone with a thermal camera and deep learning for non-invasive breast cancer screening.
Public policy	Seen as allocating resources for the larger good, AI gives policymakers sharper tools to find pain points and target spending.
New professions	AI law, covering authorship, copyright and permissible output, and data protection as a field in its own right.

Source: panel discussion. Examples as described by panellists.



"It is not about charity. There is a huge amount of money in solving real problems, and state governments are now supporting them."

Bhupesh Daheria, Moderator

Domain knowledge: the unanimous answer

Responding to a question from Dr. Kriti Srivastava on how much domain knowledge matters in fresher hiring, the panel was unanimous: it is critical.

- Virendra Pal recalled a fresher who, asked how to calculate a median, said a library does it. Dependence on libraries and chat tools carries over into shallow domain understanding.
- Many employees still cannot explain how their business makes money six months after joining: its customers, data and challenges. Without that, they cannot propose solutions.

CASE IN POINT

The missing inflation adjustment

Sudarshan Shidore described a retail demand model built on ten years of price data that ignored inflation, because no one had told the team to account for it. Adding inflation, drawn from basic retail and economics knowledge, improved the model.



“A dollar in 2012 is not equal to a dollar in 2022. You won't know this until you know the domain.”

Sudarshan Shidore, Former Chief Data Scientist, TCS

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- AI multiplies domain expertise; it does not replace it.
- Core engineering, governance and health offer large, under-served opportunities for AI talent.
- Students should collaborate across disciplines, including law, civil and mechanical engineering, and look at real problem statements from state governments, such as those listed on Assessfy.

EXHIBIT 8 Where AI talent can go beyond software

Civil and infrastructure

Better roads, low-cost housing, and contractor accountability through defect detection.

Mechanical and materials

AI-assisted design and discovery of better materials.

Electrical and chemical

Core engineering fields that lost talent to software for three decades.

Health

Low-cost, non-invasive diagnostics built on commodity devices.

Law and data protection

New practice areas in authorship, copyright, permissible output and data rights.

Governance and policy

Sharper resource allocation, child safety and development planning.

Source: Bharat AI Innovation synthesis of remarks by Bhupesh Daheria and panellists on AI beyond software.

07 AUDIENCE QUESTIONS

What recruiters will look for

Students asked the question on everyone's mind: if AI writes the code, how will recruiters tell candidates apart? Three panellists answered from three vantage points.

EXHIBIT 9 How candidates will be evaluated



Bala Singhania

Can you solve a puzzle? Can you modify your own code live, in minutes, without AI? Smart people find jobs in good markets and bad.



Sudarshan Shidore

Problem solving carried his generation through the internet, social media and fintech. It will carry this generation through AI.



Dr. Ashish Tendulkar

Fundamentals plus the ability to code alongside AI. Serving LLMs efficiently at scale needs deep systems knowledge no chatbot can supply.

Source: audience Q&A.

Why still learn C, and write code by hand?

Dr. Kriti Srivastava raised a question students often ask: why write data structures in C when Python exists? Sudarshan Shidore explained that C remains fundamental to industrial applications and teaches programming principles few languages can. Bhupesh Daheria shared a telling case: a large bank gave 100 experienced candidates from a top IT services firm a two-page program and 15 minutes to find the bug. None succeeded, and none were hired.



"People won't mind you writing code using Claude, but they want to be sure you understand each line of the code you have written."

Bhupesh Daheria, Moderator

He added that while AI generates vast volumes of code, it also creates technical debt, driving strong demand, and strong pay, for genuinely excellent coders. Mass-hiring roles will shrink, but the value of top coders will rise.

RECOMMENDATIONS

An agenda for action

Drawing on the discussion, we set out priorities for each group. The common thread: use AI freely, but build the fundamentals, judgement and ownership that make you hard to replace.

Students

- 01** Solve first, then use AI to check, improve and extend your work.
- 02** Read books and research papers, and implement what you read.
- 03** Master fundamentals: data structures, algorithms, systems, statistics and maths.
- 04** Learn the business of the sector you want to join before the interview.
- 05** Own every line of code and every slide you submit.
- 06** Cut back on short-form social media to rebuild attention.

Educators and institutions

- 01** Keep proctored paper-and-pen assessment for core concepts.
- 02** Move to continuous, multi-component evaluation.
- 03** Design applied problems using real-world data.
- 04** Allow AI in projects, but grade on presentation, defence and viva.
- 05** Build interdisciplinary projects with law, civil and mechanical departments.

Employers and recruiters

- 01** Replace recall-based screening with live problem solving and code modification.
- 02** Build experience-based evaluation sets for edge cases and production scenarios.
- 03** Hold candidates accountable for AI-assisted work through structured code reviews.
- 04** Train teams to supervise AI agents with clear guardrails.

Government and policymakers

- 01** Open up public problem statements and data to students and start-ups.
- 02** Support AI adoption in core engineering, governance and public services.
- 03** Encourage collaboration between colleges, industry and state departments on real problems.

CLOSING PERSPECTIVE

Realism, not alarm

The panel closed on realism rather than alarm. Being unprepared has always been the real risk, in every generation. AI does not change that; it raises the bar.

Those who build strong fundamentals, think independently, understand their domain and learn to direct AI with judgement will find more opportunity, not less.

Sudarshan Shidore ended with a story from a past campus recruitment drive, where a student broke down fearing her parents' reaction if she did not get into a large IT company. His message to her, and to every student in the hall: missing one big company is not the end of the world. There are many avenues, and AI is creating new ones.

The conversation continues at the Bharat AI Innovation Conference and Exhibition at the World Trade Center Mumbai on 20 to 21 November 2026, and across further Campus Series panels.



“Leave Instagram. Go to fundamentals. Build models. Make money. Generate employment.”

Bhupesh Daheria, closing remarks



“If you don't get into a big IT company, it's not the end of the world. You'll find something to do.”

Sudarshan Shidore, closing story

ABOUT

The Campus Series and its organisers



Bharat AI Innovation 2026

A national initiative inspired by the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. The 2026 edition brings 5,000+ researchers, founders, CXOs and policymakers to the World Trade Center Mumbai on 20 to 21 November 2026, with a multi-track conference, an exhibition across industry zones and an AI Impact Showcase. Visitor passes are free. Register at bharataiinnovation.com/register.

Campus Series

Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series

Free pre-event panels on campuses across India that bring industry, academia and policy together, with a large share of time for student questions. The series began at Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai, followed by Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. Host a panel: bharataiinnovation.com/campus-series.



Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai

Host institution for the session, at its campus in Vile Parle (West), Mumbai.



Aegis School of Data Science & AI

India's first school to launch a PGP in Data Science, in 2015, with over 43 batches of data science professionals graduated since. Aegis works on AI and data science for social good and governance, and runs an AI Product Factory whose projects include:

- **Khozo:** tracking child and women trafficking
- **Savnadi:** protecting water bodies
- **Aarakshak:** a sovereign AI system for proctoring, surveillance and KYC, built with Assessfy
- **Pothole detection:** for safer roads

Aegis Knowledge Trust organises Bharat AI Innovation, the Aegis Graham Bell Awards and the Data Science Congress.



Assessfy

The AI Operating System for Continuous Improvement, helping universities and institutions digitise examinations, outcome-based education and accreditation.



mUniCampus

Digital infrastructure for learning organisations, whether a university, a college or a corporate.



Aegis Graham Bell Awards

Presented by Aegis Knowledge Trust, the awards have honoured innovation across 17 editions since 2008. bellaward.com

CONTINUE THE CONVERSATION

Join us at Bharat AI Innovation 2026

World Trade Center Mumbai, 20 to 21 November

Watch the full DJSCE panel, explore upcoming Campus Series sessions, or invite the series to your campus.



Watch the panel

youtube.com/watch?v=fIPXB3mTNOM



Campus Series

bharataiinnovation.com/campus-series

ONLINE

bharataiinnovation.com

Register free for the conference and exhibition

bharataiinnovation.com/register



This publication summarises views expressed by panellists and audience members at a Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series event held at Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai. Views are those of the individuals concerned and do not necessarily represent the views of their organisations, the host institution or the organisers. Figures and examples are as cited during the discussion and have not been independently verified. Quotes have been lightly edited for clarity. © 2026 Aegis Knowledge Trust. All rights reserved.